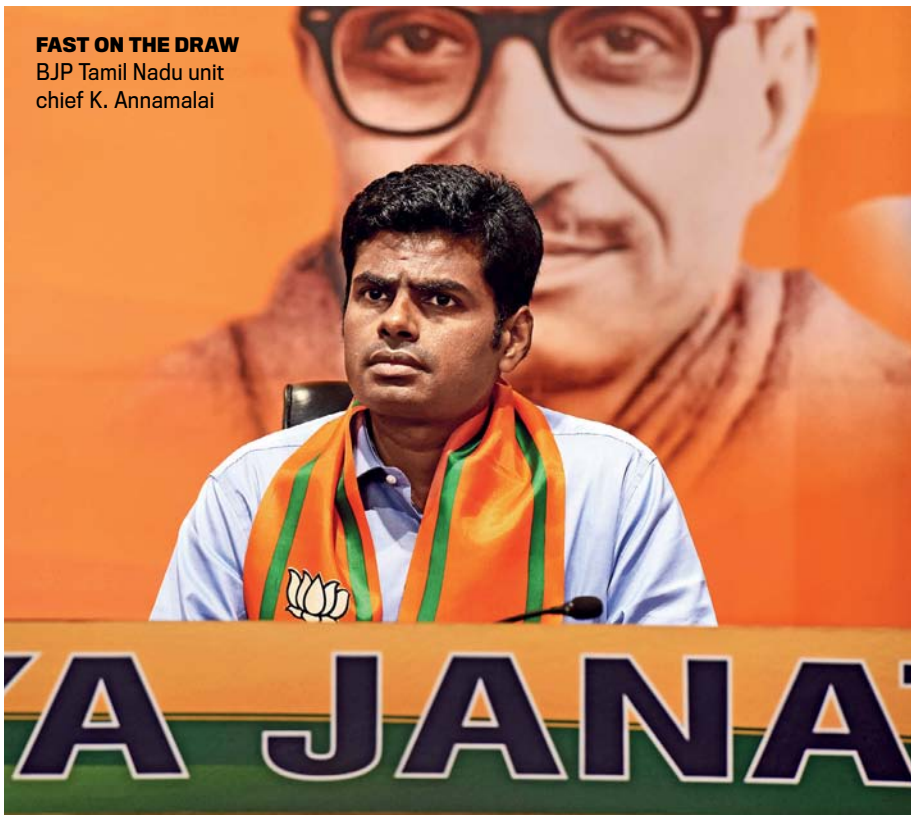
TAMIL NADU

DRAVIDIAN ROADBLOCK

By Amarnath K. Menon



FAST ON THE DRAW
BJP Tamil Nadu unit chief K. Annamalai

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Things are not looking good for the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK)-Bharatiya Janata Party alliance. In fact, some utterances coming out of Tamil Nadu should count as both an embarrassment and a warning for the BJP brass. On June 4, Sellur K. Raju, former minister and AIADMK's Madurai West MLA, accused state BJP chief K. Annamalai of "creating unnecessary flutter" for personal aggrandisement. He was alluding to frequent claims by Annamalai on the BJP's rosy prospects in Dravidian land—especially his remark that it's now the state's third largest party, eclipsing the Congress, which dominated the landscape before the advent of the Dravidian parties in the '60s. "The crowd that gathers for the BJP is like a swarm of crows that will fly away if they get nothing," Raju said, not stinting on colourful metaphor. "Our cadres are not crows waiting for breadcrumbs. They are guided by ideology."

The words signalled a creeping anger within the AIADMK, even a touch of existential panic. It came days after party veteran and organising secretary C. Ponnaiyan accused the BJP of using "double standards" in order to widen its base at the AIADMK's expense. "We have to rethink our strategy and play the role of the principal opposition party if we are not to be overshadowed by the BJP in the long run," Ponnaiyan cautioned cadres. "The BJP's growth will not augur well for the AIADMK, the state and Dravidian politics in general." Clearly, the path the AIADMK chose after the demise of J. Jayalalithaa in 2016, of virtually playing a Trojan horse to the BJP, has led to the inevitable outcome: territorial conflict.

Much of the anger is directed at Annamalai's aggressive style of putting the BJP at the forefront—instead of being content with playing a quiet supporting role to the AIADMK. Not only him, other party leaders too have absorbed that spirit. Amid renewed speculation about ousted AIADMK leader V.K. Sasikala's return to that party, BJP MLA N. Nagendran said: "If the AIADMK does not want to readmit the former interim general secretary (Sasikala), we will welcome her into the BJP." As for Ponnaiyan's charges, state BJP vice-president V.P. Duraisamy said he was merely venting his disappointment at not getting a Rajya Sabha seat.

EVEN AFTER THE AIADMK ATTACK, A WARY ANNAMALAI DOESN'T WANT TO HARM THE ALLIANCE

But Annamalai, a former IPS officer who turned 38 on June 4, is at the centre of the skirmish. How quickly he has hit his stride is partly the reason why the focus is on him. He joined the BJP in 2020, and in July 2021 was made state president—the youngest ever. His mandate is clear: to pursue the BJP's goal of going from a non-entity to an influential force in Tamil Nadu politics. With his organisational ability—take the speedy recruitment of youth—and his public pronouncements, Annamalai is leaving a mark.

As a counter to critics who accuse him of betraying Tamil Nadu in